

Alkaline Earth Metals

Forming the second column – or Group 2 – of the periodic table, these metals are not quite as reactive as their neighbours, the alkali metals, which form Group 1. Most alkaline earth metals were first found in Earth's crust as oxide compounds. Solid at room temperature, these elements have low melting and boiling points.



**Magnesium
can be made
into a flexible ribbon**

Soft metals

Most members of this group are soft, brittle metals when pure, and are easy to cut with a knife. They also break easily when they are dropped or twisted. One exception is beryllium, which is a hard, tough metal.



Silvery shine

Pure alkaline earth metals, such as calcium (seen above), are shiny. These metals are highly reflective and have a very smooth surface, which creates a mirrorlike shine.



Making alkalis

The crumbly minerals of these elements dissolve in water to form chemicals called alkalis. In the past, these minerals were called “earths”, which inspired the name of the group.

**Magnesite, a mineral
of magnesium**